1

The purpose of government

Everyone has felt the irritation of having multiple different chargers for different devices. There is a chaos of chargers with USB-B, USB-C, Apple lightning, etc., interfaces, all of which are incompatible with each other. This is operationally inconvenient as sharing of chargers is not feasible. It also leads to a greater extent of electronic waste in the form of unused chargers.

An exasperated person may say, ‘Can’t we have a government that standardizes this?’ Could a government add value by coercing all electronics companies to make only one kind of charger? At first blush, this may seem like an appealing idea. This is the sort of thing a muscular Indian government might come up with—a law that forces all technology companies to only sell consumer products in India that use (say) the USB-C charger.

While this might be plausible at first blush, when we go deeper into the problem, there are all kinds of difficulties.

If we had to have a government choose the one charger to rule them all, how would this be done? Who would choose? How would we be sure that these persons would think for the best interests of society, and command vast intellectual capacity? How do we know that the right decision will be made, despite intense lobbying by all technology companies? What if there are certain devices made in Taiwan, which are extremely capable and cost effective, but use a prohibited charger? Will we ban Indian consumers from using them?